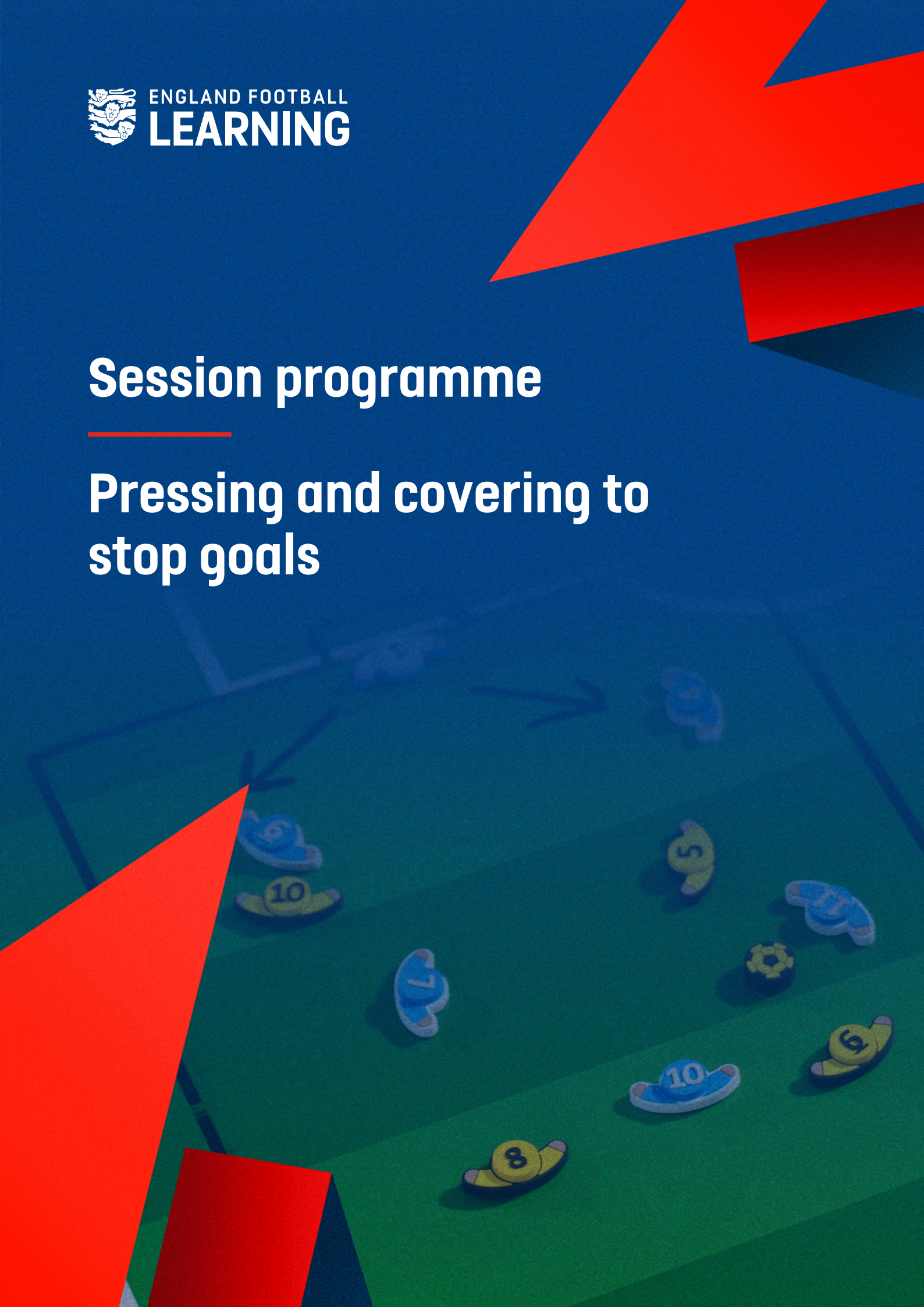


Session programme

Pressing and covering to stop goals



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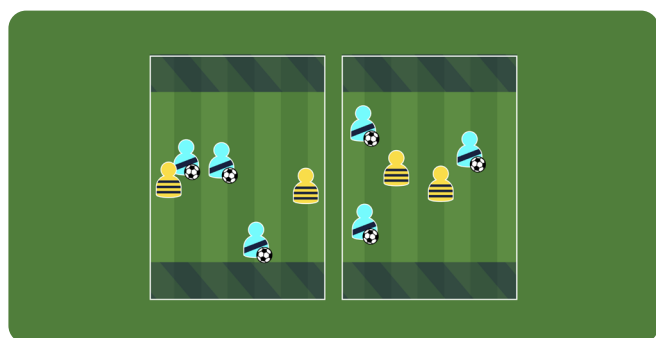
Week one: practising the press

This session will help players:

- think about when and how to press
- work with teammates to press and cover
- improve their ability to challenge.

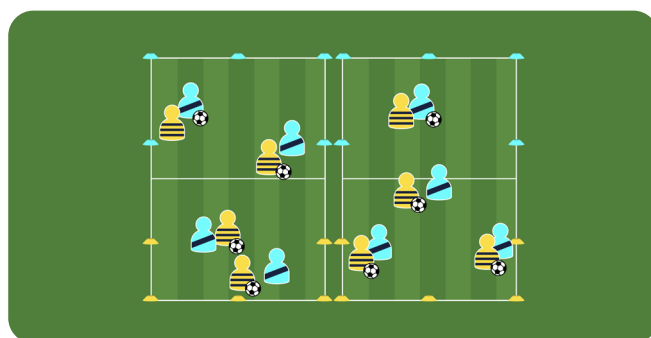
Coaching points

- Get players to think about how their body positioning can help them win the ball. If they position themselves side on, and stay low, they can better react to the movements of the player on the ball.
- Ask players to look for opportunities to challenge for the ball. A couple of good triggers are when their opponent puts their head down or takes a poor touch.
- Encourage your players to steal the ball to set up an attack.



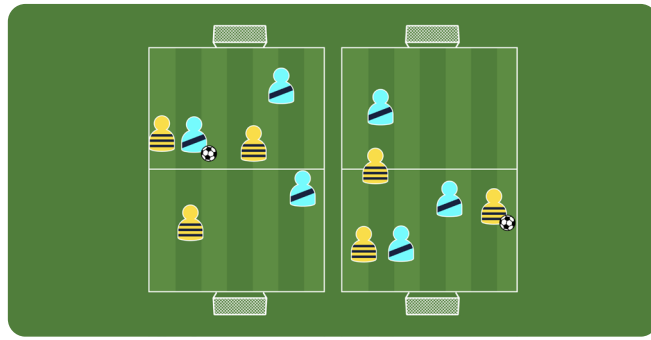
Arrival activity

- Create two 20x15-yard corridors with a safe zone at each end and two defenders in the middle.
- The rest start at one end and try to dribble to the other.
- If successful, they exit the area and go back to the start.
- If a defender steals a ball, they try to get to a safe zone with it to score a point.



Practice one

- Create two 20x15-yard areas with a halfway line.
- Split players into two teams.
- Pair them up with an opponent so everyone's in a 1v1.
- Each team has a half as their stadium.
- One player in each pair starts with a ball.
- Players need to keep it in their own stadium to win a point. Rounds last 45 seconds.



Practice two

- Create parallel pitches appropriate for the age and stage of your players.
- Put a goal at each end.
- Players take part in a normal small-sided game on each pitch for ten minutes.
- Encourage players to look for opportunities to press and steal the ball.

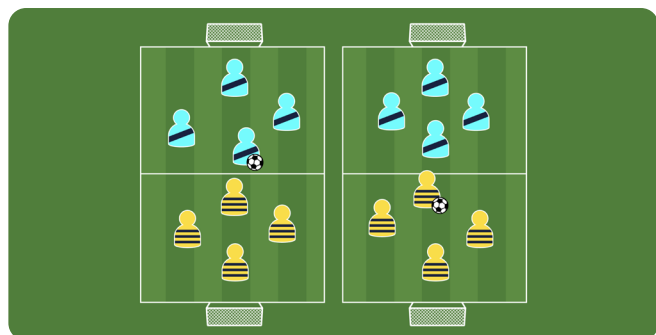
Week two: speed of the press

This session will help players:

- work on when and how to press
- use speed and body positioning effectively
- improve their ability to apply pressure to the player on the ball.

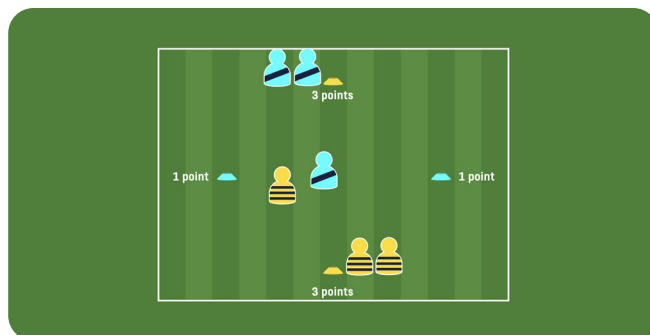
Coaching points

- Ask players to look for signs to apply pressure, such as their opponent looking down, taking a heavy touch or not having the ball under control.
- Emphasise the importance of being able to increase and decrease their speed at the right time. Defenders need to quickly get close to their opponent but slow down enough so their opponent can't use the defender's momentum against them.
- Encourage players to take a side on and lowered position to help them react to the movements of the player with the ball.



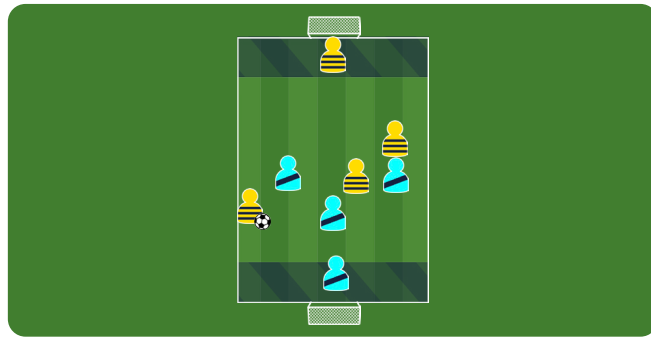
Arrival activity

- Create parallel pitches appropriate for the age and stage of your players.
- Put a goal at each end.
- Players take part in a normal small-sided game on each pitch for ten or fifteen minutes.
- Encourage players to think about how and when they could press.



Practice one

- Create a 10x10-yard diamond area for this 1v1 game.
- Attackers start on one cone with defenders on the opposite cone.
- If attackers avoid being tagged, they score a point for reaching a side cone and three points for getting to the defender's cone.
- Progress this by giving attackers a ball to run with.



Practice two

- Create an area with a zone and a goal at each end.
- Each team has a player in their own defensive zone while the rest are in the middle.
- Players work together to score but can't make a backwards pass to a teammate in the middle.
- They can pass back to the player in their defensive zone.

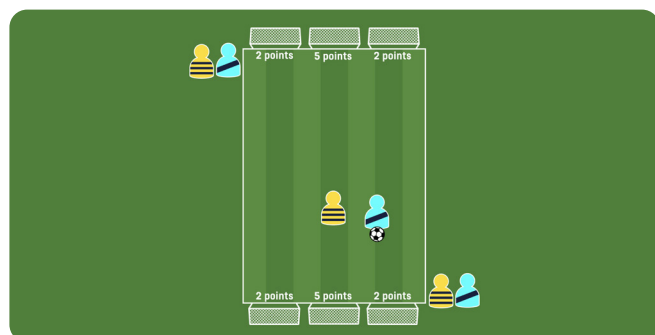
Week three: press to dictate

This session will help players:

- work on when and how to press
- improve their ability to apply pressure to the player on the ball
- dictate the direction of the player in possession.

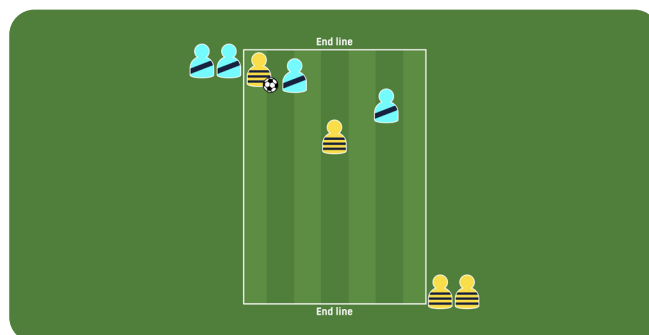
Coaching points

- Once a goal is scored or the ball goes out of play in the 1v1 and 2v2 practices, ensure the next set of players go into the middle. The original attackers and defenders go off the pitch and swap roles for their next turn.
- Ask players to think about their positioning and angle of approach when pressing. Doing this well can help players dictate what their opponent does next. For example, forcing a player out wide in the first activity can direct them out of play or towards the side goals which are worth less than the middle goal.



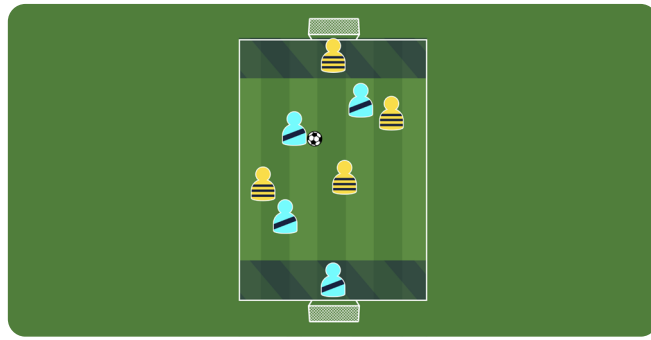
Arrival activity

- Create 15x10-yard areas with three goals at each end for a 1v1 activity.
- Have other pairs waiting outside.
- The attacker receives the ball and goes for goal.
- Scoring in the middle goal is worth five points, the two side goals are worth one point.
- The defender can win the ball back and score too.
- When a goal is scored, the two players leave, and a new attacker and defender take to the pitch.
- The ball gets played to the attacker to start the 1v1 battle.
- Meanwhile, the original attacker and defender swap roles the next time they play.



Practice one

- Remove the goals from the first activity for this 2v2 practice.
- Players look to beat their opponents and dribble past the end line to score.



Practice two

- Create an area with a zone and a goal at each end.
- Each team has a player in their own defensive zone while the rest are in the middle.
- Players work together to score but can't make a backwards pass to a teammate in the middle.
- They can pass back to the player in their defensive zone.

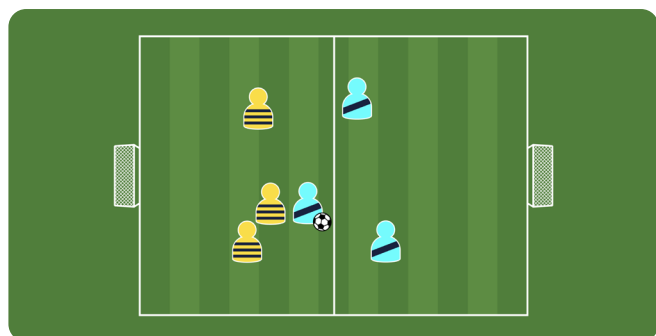
Week four: locked in

This session will help players:

- work on when and how to press
- scan to improve decision-making
- recognise when they need to delay an opponent.

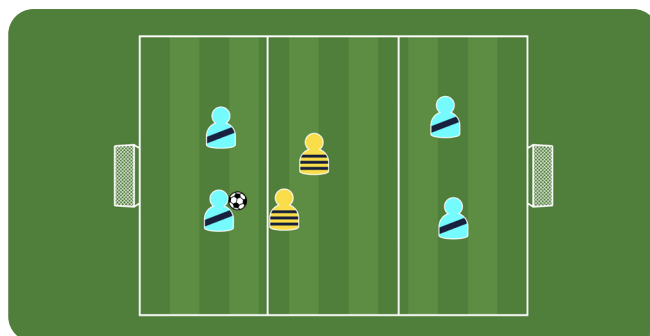
Coaching points

- During the 'part' section of this session, ensure defenders switch roles with the pair of attackers if they've scored in their goal.
- Get players thinking about if they can reach the player who is receiving the ball as they take their first touch or not. If they can't, they need to delay their opponent and position themselves in a way to encourage play in the desired direction.
- Emphasise the importance of scanning. Players need to scan to see what's around them. Do they, or the closest defender, have cover behind them, or are they isolated? If they don't have cover, they might need to think about delaying the opponent until more support arrives.
- Ask players to look for poor passes, poor first touches and the direction of a first touch to help make the decision to press or delay.



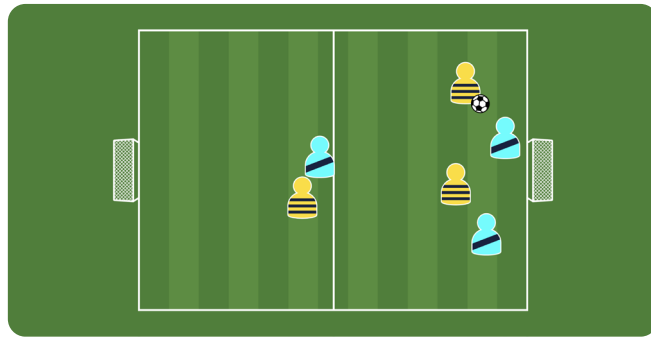
Practice one

- Create 30x20-yard pitches with a goal at each end and a halfway line.
- In this game, the side on the ball can move anywhere.
- The side without it are locked in whichever half they were in when they lost possession.
- If they win the ball back, they can then move anywhere to attack and score.



Practice two

- Split your pitches into thirds.
- Have at least two attackers locked in the end thirds and two defenders in the middle.
- One defender can go press.
- The head height rule is in place.
- Attackers work the ball from one side to the other.
- If the defenders win the ball, they break out to attack either goal.



Practice three

- As this is a whole-part-whole session, return to the first practice.

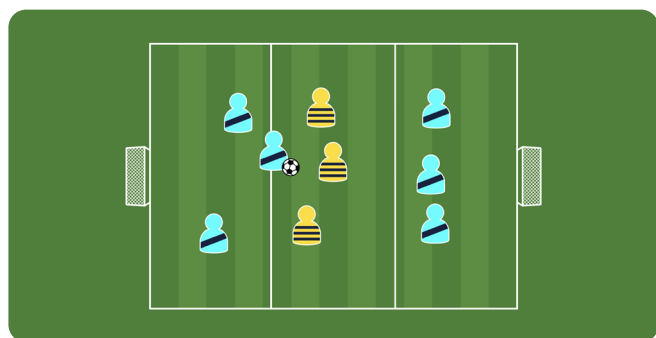
Week five: swift support

This session will help players:

- work on when and how to press
- scan to improve decision-making
- recognise when to apply pressure and when to cover a teammate.

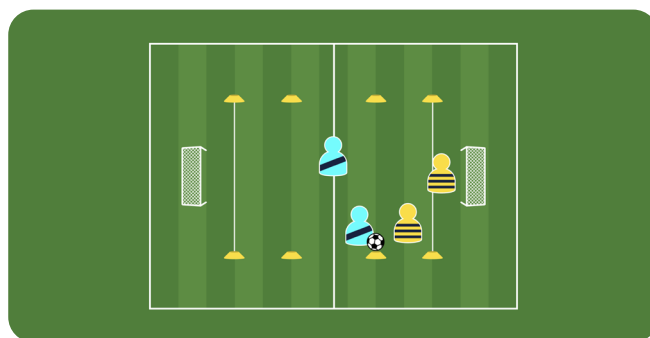
Coaching points

- Encourage players to scan to identify who is the closest defender that can apply pressure to the opponent on the ball.
- Remind players that as the ball moves, the role of pressing and covering player may change.
- Observe players on the line to see if they're scanning the pitch for the position of their teammates and the ball. This should help them move up and down to cover and protect the goal.



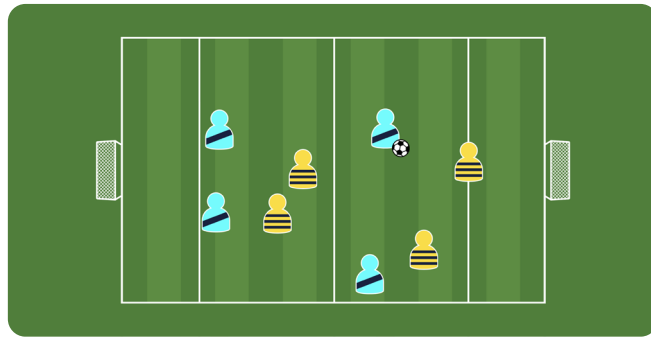
Practice one

- Split your pitch into thirds.
- Have attackers in the end thirds and defenders in the middle.
- Most players are locked in but the attacker on the ball can drive into the middle.
- Attackers work the ball from one side to the other.
- If the defenders win the ball, they break out to attack either goal.



Practice two

- Set up an area for a 2v2 activity.
- Have a mini-goal behind a line at each end.
- The idea for both teams is to combine to score.
- The team that doesn't have the ball works together to always have one player pressing.
- The other offers covering support on the line in front of their goal.



Practice two – progression

- To progress the previous practice, extend the pitch and add another line in for a defender to screen.
- Now play the same game but with a 4v4.
- Players could start being locked into their areas.

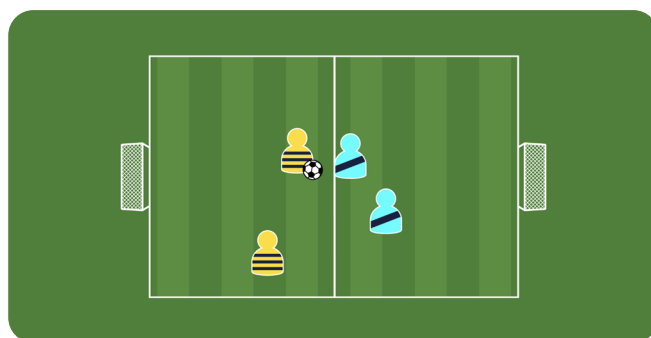
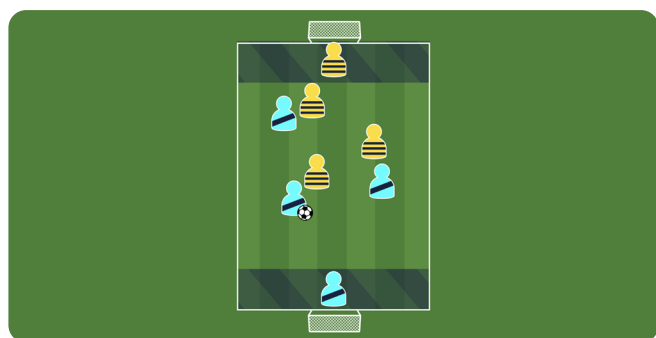
Week six: festival week

This session will help players:

- know when and how to press
- understand when to apply pressure and when to cover a teammate.

Coaching points

- Time the games to provide high intensity and rest periods. As a guide you could rotate and mix up teams every eight minutes. If players are engaged and enjoying it, let the games last longer. Change it up quicker if players are getting frustrated. Be aware that two games are 3v3 and one is a 2v2, so you need to work with players to manage the teams.
- Ask players to think about their positioning and angle of approach when pressing.
- Emphasise the importance of scanning. Players need to scan to see what's around them.
- Ask players to look for opportunities to challenge for the ball. A couple of good triggers are when their opponent puts their head down or takes a poor touch. Then encourage your players to steal the ball to set up an attack.

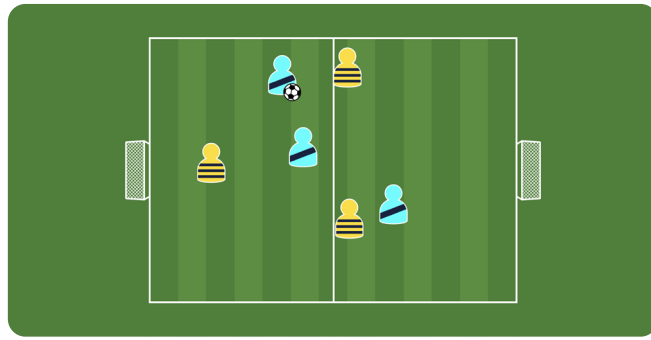


Arrival activity

- Create an area with a zone and a goal at each end.
- Each team has a player in their own defensive zone while the rest are in the middle.
- Players work together to score but can't make a backwards pass to a teammate in the middle.
- But they can pass back to the player in their defensive zone.

Practice one

- Set up a pitch for a 2v2 activity.
- This is a normal game.
- The focus is on seeing if players can carry out what they've learnt about pressing and covering over the last few weeks.



Practice two

- Create a pitch with a goal at each end and a halfway line.
- In this 3v3 or 4v4 activity, the side on the ball can move anywhere.
- The side without it are locked in whichever half they were in when they lost possession.
- If they win the ball back, they can then move anywhere to attack and score.